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AE Sales Process — FY27 Field Guide

Use this document stage-by-stage. Each section tells you what to prepare, what to do on the call, what gates you need to clear, and what your next step is. Never skip a stage.

PREP Research & Prep	SS1 Introduction	SS2 Deep Discovery	SS3 PIE — Custom Demo	SS4 Scoping & Proposal
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QUICK REFERENCE: Stage Gate Checklist

Stage	Duration	Key Requirement to Enter	Must-Have to Exit
PREP	Before every call	Any new opportunity or upcoming call	Tools run, research complete, goals defined
SS1	~30 min	Prep complete, no slides, Algospay checked	Both Biz + Tech POC confirmed for Discovery; quantifiable pain shared; next step scheduled
SS2	60 min	SS1 exit criteria met; SE pre-call done	Vision-to-Value delivered; eval path confirmed; PIE buy-in secured
SS3	90 min	PIE built; pitch deck ready; impl. plan drafted with Post-Sales	Roles defined; integration complexity surfaced; implementation review complete
SS4	Ongoing	All prior gates cleared; no T-shirt sizing conversations still open	ROI confirmed; proposal delivered; commercial terms anchored to impact

PREP

Research & Prep — Before Every Call

Required before SS1 and deepened before every subsequent stage

CORE TOOLS — Use These Before Every Call

- [AI Sales Toolkit](#)
- [Algospay Chrome Plugin](#) - detect Algolia / C.io beacon on prospect site
- [Customer Implementations](#)
- SFDC / Gong - review old opps, call recordings, existing channels
- Slackbot - search internal Slack intel (#cust, #sales, #AE channels)

DEEPER PREP (SS2 and beyond)

- Deeper stakeholder research
- Define what success looks like for this call — what do THEY need to leave knowing?
- Org mapping — who are all the players?

- Name-drops for tech stack + industry vertical
- Build Value Prompter "What We Heard" slide
- Run MegGPT for merch context
- Pull C.io competitive brief

OPERATING RHYTHM

- Deal Reviews — ongoing pipeline health checks
- Value Prompter Review — validate accuracy per opp
- Gong Dashboard — call tracking & coaching
- Value Prompter Engineering — continuous improvement loop

NEXT

When prep is done → move to SS1: Introduction Call



SS1

Introduction — First Call

~30 minutes • No slides • Assume C.io is in the deal if ICP of a certain size

BEFORE THIS CALL

- Do NOT bring slides — this is a conversation, not a pitch
- Run a high-level search audit using the AI Sales Toolkit
- Identify 2–3 live customer implementations relevant to your audience and grounded in outcomes — use the Implementation Explorer and Slackbot (#cust, #AE, #Sales channels)
- Check Algospys: is the C.io beacon present on the prospect's site?

GOALS FOR THIS CALL

- Determine if C.io is already in the deal
- Get answers to the Value Prompter
- Gain buy-in for a deep-dive Discovery (this is NOT the discovery)
- Confirm: competition, timing, who owns budget and/or success
- Introduce the evaluation process structure

DEEP DIVE DISCOVERY FRAMING — Use This Language

- "Algolia works best when both tech and business teams are working together."
- "We're the only solution in this space that's both technically flexible and easy to adopt for business teams."
- "If you only want to approach this from one side — tech or merch — there are better options. Algolia is built for where those two perspectives intersect."

IF THEY ASK FOR PRICING

- Give T-shirt sizes only. Punt any detailed scoping conversation to SS4.

GREEN / YELLOW / RED FLAGS

✓ GREEN — Good Signs

⚠ YELLOW — Probe Further

🚩 RED — Qualification Risk



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- "We have specific requirements for integrating"
- "We have opinions on product order"
- Both tech and business stakeholders want to be involved

- "Our search just sucks"
- Unable to quantify the pain
- No clear timeline or compelling event

- "We want to automate as much as possible"
- "We're not super interested in how it works"
- No technical or implementation resources available
- Anecdotal, superficial pain — no requirements

EXIT CRITERIA — Do Not Move to SS2 Without These

- ✓ Both a Technical POC and a Business POC confirmed for Discovery
- ✓ Prospect has shared a quantifiable need, pain, or goal (path to business case)
- ✓ Prospect is a target persona with authority, influence, or can provide access to that role
- ✓ Algolia-driven next step scheduled — goal is to build a business case or evaluate Algolia
- ✓ Prospect has shared enough to directionally size the opportunity
- ✓ Commitment to the Deep Dive Discovery confirmed

NEXT

Exit SS1 → Schedule SS2: Deep Discovery with AE + SE + Biz + Tech stakeholders



SS2

Discovery — Technical & Merch Deep Dive

60 minutes • Required: Biz + Tech + SE + 1st Line Manager

BEFORE THIS CALL

- Meet with your SE for 30 minutes — structured pre-call, not ad hoc
- Agree on the goals of the session: what does the prospect need to understand? What info do you need?
- Define the outcome — this drives your discovery path

CALL AGENDA

- 25 min — Technical Discovery (focus: Search)
- 25 min — Business Discovery (focus: Merch / Category / Browse / Agents)
 - If you have a strong prospect, consider bringing Meg or prepping with her ahead of time
- 5 min — Summary: Vision-to-Value + PIE Journey overview

HOW TO RUN THE DISCOVERY

- Focus on the HOW, not just the WHAT
- Ask 3 'WHY's behind every pain point — keep digging and listening
- Understand the internal obstacles standing between the prospect and their goals

GOALS FOR THIS CALL

- Confirm the correct eval path and why the custom demo path is the right one
- Get all Value Prompter answers to build the Anxiety Statement



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- Deliver the Vision-to-Value
- If you can't get past surface level: be prepared with front-end demo examples and dashboard views

RESOURCES

- Merchandising Discovery Guide — (see internal tab)
- General Discovery Guide — BANT, MEDDPICC (Google Sheets link in source doc)

FINAL STEP IN THIS CALL

- Deliver the Vision-to-Value speech
- Get buy-in for the Customer Playbook / PIE (Pre-Implementation Environment)
- Confirm the evaluation process

EXIT CRITERIA — Do Not Move to SS3 Without These

- ✓ Vision-to-Value documented and delivered
- ✓ Compelling event confirmed
- ✓ Org map complete — all key stakeholders identified
- ✓ Clear technical requirements documented
- ✓ Eval path confirmed — do not proceed to demo until discovery is fully complete
- ✓ Buy-in secured for PIE (Pre-Implementation Environment)

NEXT

Exit SS2 → Build PIE and schedule SS3: Custom Demo + Go Live Plan



SS3

POC Phase 1 — Custom Demo + Go Live Plan

90-minute session • Pitch (15m) + PIE Demo (50m) + Implementation Plan (15m)

PRE-REQUISITES — Complete Before Scheduling This Session

- Build the Pre-Implementation Environment (PIE) using the Internal PIE Playbook
 - Week 1: Demo Vetting
 - Week 2: Innovation Sprints 1 and 2
 - Week 3: Implementation Plan for Go Live
- Create the Competitive Pitch Deck
- Design the Implementation Plan with Post-Sales

CALL AGENDA

- 15 min — Competitive Pitch (recap what you heard, differentiation framework)
- 50 min — Present PIE
- 15 min — Implementation Plan review

PITCH GOALS



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- Recap what you heard — both Business and Technical
- Framework: Anxiety Statement → 3–5 Algolia Differentiators → Differentiated Customer Examples
- Theme: The How vs. the What — real MVP, real differentiators, real customer stories, real ROI

PIE PRESENTATION GOALS

- Work with your SC to build the PIE and agenda — this should NOT be only the SE speaking
- AE role: map every visual to requirements and value statements
 - "Here's what you just saw..."
 - "Here's why that matters / is differentiated..."
 - "Here's what you're about to see next..."
- Validate everything against the Anxiety Question

IMPLEMENTATION PLAN GOALS

- Customize the overview to the prospect's specific needs
- Resources required by the customer
- Define a clear timeline
- Set success criteria: "We'll consider this a success if X, Y, Z happens"

EXIT CRITERIA — Do Not Move to SS4 Without These

- ✓ Roles & responsibilities defined — both sides
- ✓ Integration complexity surfaced and understood
- ✓ Governance clarified
- ✓ Implementation review completed — block the proposal until this is done
- ✓ Prospect has validated the custom demo against their stated requirements
- ✓ Anxiety Statement addressed and confirmed

NEXT Exit SS3 → Move to SS4: Scoping & Proposal (no pricing before this point)



SS4

Scoping & Proposal

No scoping or pricing effort before SS4 • T-shirt sizes only until now

PRE-REQUISITES — Complete After Scoping / Before Proposal Call

- Pre-Proposal Call (30 min) — validate assumptions before presenting a proposal
- Review the Proposal Playbook while building the Proposal Deck

PRE-PROPOSAL CALL GOALS — Avoiding Last-Second Surprises

- VALIDATE
 - What success looks like
 - Which KPIs matter most



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- What scope assumptions are correct
- Which requirements are most-haves
- What current-state costs or risks exist
- What Algolia is replacing, enabling, and removing
- Which stakeholders and timeline matter for approval

Required for Proposal - DO NOT PROCEED TO PROPOSAL UNLESS VALIDATED

- ✓ Scoping document is complete
- ✓ Pre-proposal call has happened
- ✓ KPIs/success criteria are known and validated
- ✓ Anxiety statement is confirmed
- ✓ Scope assumptions are validated
- ✓ Current-state pain is understood
- ✓ Cost of inaction is at least directionally clear
- ✓ Required add-ons are confirmed
- ✓ AE + SE agree pricing is ready to present

PROPOSAL RULES

- Proposal ≠ SOW — do not conflate the two
- No scoping before SS4 — T-shirt sizes only until this stage
- Enterprise Foundation = trusted expert-level partnership (SLAs, uptime, proactive guidance)
- Do not use the proposal deck with placeholder content or generic assumptions (tailor it)

COMMERCIAL FRAMING

- T-shirt sizing first — anchor before you detail
- ROI anchored to measurable lift — use the ROI model
- Enterprise Foundation positioning: SLA, uptime, partnership (not just product)
- Pricing structure alignment before formal proposal delivery

C.IO COUNTER-NARRATIVE — Know This Cold

- Their plays: All in · One price · White glove · ROI guarantee / 3% · Free bot traffic · No implementation resources required
- Their attack on us: "Algolia will nickel and dime you" / "consumption-based pricing is too expensive"

Their Claim	Our Response
3% ROI Guarantee	3% is table stakes — they control the guarantee metrics. Ask: what's the value of 4 min vs. 43 min of downtime per month?
"It's free"	It's not free — it's factored into the cost. And you get no control over your own go-live.
Consumption pricing is too expensive	You don't need an unlimited plan. We eliminate consumption concerns in term 1, then right-size after we know your usage.



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CUSTOMER BENEFIT OF ALGOLIA — Your Closing Frame

- No risk
- Easy and simple to adopt
- Trusted expert-level partnership
- Accelerates time to value

EXIT CRITERIA — Required to Close

- ✓ ROI alignment confirmed with business stakeholders
- ✓ Formal proposal delivered
- ✓ No early scoping has occurred prior to this stage
- ✓ Proposal is not being confused with an SOW
- ✓ Commercial terms anchored to measurable impact — not just price

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